them. That proved to be his undoing. Gowarikar took over as the VSSC director from Brahm Prakash in May 1972.

That marked the beginning of another round of power tussle between the two men, and I was caught in the crossfire. I never approved of Muthunayagam's ways, but there was no escaping Gowarikar's barbs as I continued to report to Muthunayagam and delivered for the team, which had by now graduated to a propulsion unit, just short of being a separate centre. Gowarikar, anyway, was not favourably inclined to my ideas of developing a liquid propulsion system and had consistently tried to puncture the Vernon project—something that he failed to do.

Some colleagues would warn me that Gowarikar would get my scalp—by hook or crook.

'One wrong step and he will fix you,' said a colleague.

I told him I was not scared since I am not party to any wrongdoing. This warning rang in my mind later when Gowarikar, then VSSC director, insisted that I head a committee that decided on recruitment of drivers. I said I was too busy with my work and could not spare time for such matters. Later, I was told that a driver was appointed out of turn, and had I been the head of the committee, I would have been answerable.

Another incident that reminded me to tread cautiously happened when I was heading another such committee to recruit some casual workers. One day I was surprised to see a VSSC driver at my door. He had come with a request: a woman relative of his had applied for a casual job in VSSC. I, as a member of the recruitment panel, should help her get the job.

I told him I will consider her if she fits the job. Thanking me, the driver fished out a long cover from his trousers pocket and placed it on the drawing room table.

'A small token of appreciation, sir,' he said.

I looked at the cover and saw a bundle of currency notes in it. I started shivering in anger.

'Take the bloody cover and run, you scoundrel,' I shouted. Hearing this, my wife came down the stairs from the floor above. The driver was still there, muttering something. I moved towards the telephone in the corner of the drawing room.

'You take that trash and leave now, or I call the police,' I said.